

Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn Statements

(internal, RU only)

[all (supplementary) materials are included or linked from here including teaching portfolio]

Friday 21st August, 2026 09:16

Contents

1 Research	1
2 Teaching (teaching portfolio)	3
3 Service	5
4 Appendix	6
4.1 Research: my research in DPPA, and scientometrics (science metrics)	6
4.2 Teaching (teaching portfolio cont'd)	8
4.2.1 Teaching in DPPA	9
4.2.2 Letters from students	10
4.2.3 Student evaluations—explaining few courses with lower evaluations	14
4.2.4 Paul Jargowsky class visitation, and my response	15
4.3 Service for DPPA	21
5 Bibliography	22

Background information

Hopefully I am just overthinking, and it will be quick and easy, in which case you can skip this section and appendices. But just in case I provide in Appendices extra background information that should be helpful if the case gets difficult.

My home department, Public Policy and Administration (DPPA), has some strong personalities with equally strong opinions—I pre-emptively respond to those in Appendix. All I am asking for is a fair evaluation based on objective evidence. For instance, see evidence of my teaching and service in CV and this document.

There are no DPPA faculty in my research area, happiness, and DPPA might have solicited external letters from outside of my field like economics. See what the experts in happiness research say—these should be hopefully the external letters.

1 Research

I am in the field of social indicators, quality of life, wellbeing, and life satisfaction. The main journals are Applied Research in Quality of Life (ARIQ) and Social Indicators Research (SIR).¹ I am on the editorial boards of both. The main academic/professional organization is International Society for Quality-of-Life Studies (ISQOLS). ARIQ may be less known across social sciences than SIR, but it is the flagship journal of ISQOLS. My field is thinner on theory than other social science, (post-)positivist, and quantitative—about patterns,

¹ Journal of Happiness Studies has shifted towards positive psychology and happiness economics.

relationships, and effects—but rather correlational than causal. (Quasi-)experiments are very rare, and there are more descriptions and visualizations than economics and statistics. My field is somewhere between geography, sociology, psychology, and philosophy.²

All research is (supposed to be) new in some sense, but my research is more original/innovative than most. Many contribute only incrementally, say by slightly improving a model, adding an interaction or instrumental variables. My contribution is new ideas—human creativity is important in current AI age. I have creative ideas, and then able to find the right data to test them. I was the first to look at several relationships:³ energy use→happiness (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Altman 2019), social v individual religiosity→happiness across countries (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2010) and →trust in the US (Valente and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2021), religiosity→creativity across space (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015b), and person v society level politics→happiness (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2014).

My main area of research has been urban-rural happiness gradient, a term coined in my early paper on the topic: “An urban-rural happiness gradient” (Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2011). This line of research is not entirely new—it has been studied in a quantitative fashion in a limited way in the 70s and philosophically since antiquity—but mine are the first studies in modern times.⁴ And I have a related line of research looking at livability of places: Okulicz-Kozaryn (2013a), Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2019a).

My urban-rural happiness gradient research includes careful gradient elaboration (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2017) and theory-rich Okulicz-Kozaryn and Mazelis (2018). As the research has matured, I added: generational differences (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2019b), adolescence (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2020), panel data (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023), elaborated happiness measurement (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2024), and Covid19's effect (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2026). Finally, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021) shows that urban unhappiness is common across countries.

I work with students to explore the gradient further: examined population change instead of level (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2024), and turned to non-WEIRD (Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic) societies: India (Deb and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023), Egypt (Mikhaeil et al. 2024), and Colombia (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2026).

I am at the forefront of the urban-rural happiness debate.⁵ Some may argue that happiness has little to do with public policy and administration—nothing further from the truth.⁶

Near-future trajectory remains similar: mostly urban-rural happiness gradient and regional happiness, adding Latin American focus (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Martinez 2025). I plan to spend more time on grant writing to grow my research group, hire students and post-docs, and do course buy-outs.⁷

Since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, I have published 37 peer-reviewed articles, including 7 in *Cities*, a journal with impact factor (IF)=8.1, higher than the top journal in public administration in the US,⁸ *Public Administration Review* with IF=7.2.⁹ Since 2017 I have also published 4 articles in *Social Indicators Research*, and 9 in *Applied Research in Quality of Life*, both leading/main journals in my field. I am also collegial and collaborative—I've

²Geography is a notable part of it—my research intersects with geography: regions, and especially urban-rural gradient. This is a subjective description of the field, or perhaps sub-field, and this is where I fit. There are other fields/sub-fields, notably positive psychology and happiness economics—they are related but different in important ways. My field is well described by its pioneer, Alex Michalos: Michalos (2014b,a). The key point is that it is a full-blown stand-alone few hundred strong field with its own thriving organization ISQOLS hosting large annual conference plus smaller online and regional conferences and we have 2 main journals: *SIR* and *ARIQ* (and several smaller ones).

³In quantitative way, focusing on and elaborating the relationship (not just listing among others or controlling for it). You will see in my many papers that the idea is indeed the first of its kind—nobody has looked at the relationship before in this way.

⁴There is a 30-40 year generational gap between mostly 70s and very few in early 80s versus my first study in 2009.

⁵For instance see the discussion in framing essay IV in Edited by Pia Heike Johansen and Fisker (2022). Likewise the literature has picked on “energy-happiness paradox”—the term that I have coined (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Altman 2019), for instance see: Nasrudin et al. (2022), Park et al. (2025), Bakehe et al. (2026), Du and Zhang (2025). And I was just added (2026) to the editorial board of *Applied Research in Quality of Life*: “Dear Adam,[...]You stand out as a top candidate given your excellent work and expertise on quality of life. [...] We consider Editorial Review Board members as guardians of the academic quality of the journal and trusted advisors to the editorial team.”

⁶See Diener (2009) and my own Okulicz-Kozaryn (2016). Likewise, there are policy implications, e.g., Okulicz-Kozaryn (2015a), Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. (2014), Okulicz-Kozaryn and Golden (2017). My *Cities* papers have “takeaways for policy/practice,” e.g., Mikhaeil et al. (2024), Deb and Okulicz-Kozaryn (2023), Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2022), and even if the section is missing, there are still policy implications, e.g., Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021).

⁷My past external funding includes the prestigious Polish National Science Foundation (PI), equivalent of the US Natl Science Foundation. Just recently I have been a PI on Rutgers Camden Chancellor's interdisciplinary research collaboration grant to conduct happiness research in Colombia. And currently, I spend more time on pivot, and working on <https://www.nsf.gov/funding/opportunities/isp-infrastructure-systems-people>

⁸I am in a department of public policy and administration in the US.

⁹<https://www.scimagojr.com/journalsearch.php?q=16956&tip=sid> and <https://www.scimagojr.com/journalsearch.php?q=17167&tip=sid>

coauthored with over 20 authors (Scopus), and my citations more than tripled (Scopus) or more than doubled (Google Scholar) since 2017. See details and more metrics in Appendix.

2 Teaching (teaching portfolio)¹⁰

Something I have dreaded as a student, and promised myself I won't do on the other side as an instructor. Style over substance: prioritizing appearance, aesthetics, and presentation over actual quality, meaning, and functionality—it looks and sounds impressive but lacks value, real utility—just like much of social science prose (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2013b). Instruction is unnecessarily fluffy and ornamented, often grandiose as if the goal is to put student in a sense of awe (Dawkins 2004). The problem seems especially acute in political science and public policy and administration.

Now as an instructor I skip the fluff and cut to the chase—convey practical information efficiently. Usefulness/utility is the key. Learning by doing, no memorizing—for instance, students bring their own data and we apply skills and tools learned in the class to the data, no exams. When I was a student I was forced to memorize theory and formulas and read hundreds of pages of formal texts. But I wasn't taught how to use the skills and the tools. I condense the material, make it relevant, maximize utility/usefulness with minimum effort, focus on what's most important in most accessible practical hands on way.¹¹

I decrease instruction and increase interaction: discussions, presentations, “flip the class,”¹² and extra labs in addition to the class. Such interactive social approach seems even more important in current reality: short attention span, information overload, AI, and mental health problems. We need to connect, be at ease, have good energy, and even some fun in class—it shouldn't be tedious and gruesome, at least not all of it. It is not watering down the curriculum. I provide plenty of extra/bonus materials so that it is customized to a student, doesn't overwhelm with unnecessary stuff, but provides enough depth and individual learning path. Pleasant learning experience matters, but so do outcomes.

I want my teaching to produce results. Learning (and motivation) is the direct result. But then comes transfer of knowledge, ability to apply that learned information. We need results either in academia or outside of it.

I have supervised 9 dissertations (5 in-progress). Four PhDs have graduated, and all have a job. One is at SIPRI (Stockholm International Peace Research Institute), a think-tank ranked 11th or 31st worldwide.¹³ Another one at Virginia Tech and the other 2 were employed at Rutgers when graduated. My students publish. Since 2021, we have published 10 peer-reviewed papers with my students in good journals including 3 in top ranked *Cities* with Impact Factor of 8.1.

One highlight is that the skills learned in the classes not only work in the academic research, but also in the real world: “The classes I took with you are helping not only my scholarship, but my day job [...] I greatly appreciate it.” and “subject: Received a Job Offer [...] I would like to thank you for all of the guidance and knowledge during all of your data-related courses the past several semesters to help me get to the point I am at today.” and “since graduating I have continued to pursue more projects in the coding world. Some analysis projects, business models, [...] I appreciate all the help and motivation you gave me in class as it helped me to really see what I can come up with from all of the useful tools, how to plan and build on projects, and skills gained from having you as my professor.”

I try to guide students individually, in the grand scheme of things, teaching is about helping students become who they are, and everyone is little different. This is another reason for forcing less required material and making more available as bonus/extra for self-actualization. I make sure I am available and approachable for students spending extra time outside of classroom: working on

¹⁰This section together with teaching appendix in this document serve as my teaching portfolio. For a list of classes that I teach see CV.

¹¹Students appreciate my teaching style, e.g., “left a lasting impression on me and I appreciated your approach and teaching style” and “Your passion for education has inspired and impacted me in so many ways. Your commitment to helping your students grow and learn is truly admirable. Thank you for all that you do!”

¹²Work on projects and homework collaboratively in class as opposed to home as done traditionally.

¹³<https://thinktankalert.com/rankings> and <https://guides.library.upenn.edu/c.php?g=1035991&p=7509972>

papers, being accessible via zoom and in person, including when on sabbatical.¹⁴

A final point on my teaching philosophy. I support public/civic service/engagement in my teaching. All my classes encourage (but not force) and give extra credit for it. And I support students even after the class in their civic endeavors—see service section. But this is not local politics/activism, it is evidence based, data driven analysis and problem-solving. It is rather positivist “what is,” than normative “what should be,”¹⁵ I support in my teaching old fashioned critical thinking, and I don’t believe classroom is a place for political indoctrination of the students. I’m (post-)positivist in my teaching—I encourage students to try to get closer to the objective truth through evidence and data. Activism and political action are better left to politicians.

I concluded my teaching philosophy, now turning to technicalities. One highlight is unusually heavy curriculum development. Since coming to Rutgers-Camden in 2012, I have taught over 10 different classes (see CV), developed from scratch most of them, including 3 courses in 2023 for our new data science program. I am updating my teaching materials each time I teach a class, and I am working on my teaching materials relatively continuously—for instance my visualization class has been updated over 200 times over past 3 years: <https://github.com/theaok/vis/commits/main/>¹⁶

I teach, mentor, and support students from different programs. In my home department of public policy and administration (DPPA), I teach regularly in Masters of Public Administration (MPA) and MS and PhD in Public Affairs, but I also teach regularly students from MS in Data science in my always cross listed DPPA courses. Often there are also few PhDs from Prevention Science, and occasionally masters students from other departments such as Psychology, and Criminology and Sociology.

I strive to improve my teaching: I attended cybersecurity training,¹⁷ and 2024 Instructional Design and Technology (IDT) workshop on “Crafting the Learner-Centered Syllabus.” In 2026 attended OTEAR RU “Developing a Teaching Portfolio” (Virtual Interactive Workshop), and 2 RU-Camden IDT webinars “Teaching in Zoom: Best practices” and “Communicating with students: Best practices”¹⁸

My teaching strength and preference is data science classes, but also happiness class that aligns with my research. I have been also developing a new class “social indicators” that would be broader than just happiness and include topics such as trust, freedom, and meaning. This would also align with my editorial position at Social Indicators Research journal.

I am interested in teaching short courses / micro-credentials. I have already taught a short GIS course twice (<https://theaok.github.io/shortGIS/>), informally, for my colleagues from the department and other faculty from Arts and Sciences, and for Walter Rand Institute. But I would like to teach more often and other short courses. There are Micro-credentials and Digital Badges that I would like to participate in.

I am 2025 recipient of department’s Jay A Sigler award for “outstanding service and dedication to students” (awarded by students); the plaque says “this award is given to the faculty member who exhibits a commitment to student’s academic development and personal growth.”

¹⁴Now in Spring 2026 I am on sabbatical, but I still have 4 students enrolled in my dissertation hours, working with another one informally on dissertation (starting formally in Fall) and I work with other students on papers informally (“summer research” projects not enrolled formally in a class). See CV.

¹⁵Similar to Network of Schools of Public Policy, Affairs, and Administration (NASPAA) competency: “to analyze, synthesize, think critically, solve problems and make decisions.” Invariably, some activism creeps in—the challenge is to unlearn what students “learn” in some other classes. And some forms of activism as in “policy implications” may be useful as long as it is kept to the minimum and follows from actual research and is evidence based.

¹⁶Most GitHub pushes are small incremental updates and cosmetic fixes, still >200 pushes is a considerable volume of updates. The point is that I put effort to revise, update, upgrade, extend, etc the teaching materials frequently. (Still I do take long multi-week breaks for research only).

¹⁷2026 KnowBe4 Security Awareness Training, Cybersecurity Essentials: Secure Passwords, and Introduction to IT Security Policies—these enhance my classroom teaching—most of my courses involve computer coding or data science—cybersecurity matters more there than in usual social science courses.

¹⁸<https://rutgers.instructure.com/courses/83839> and https://ru-stream.rutgers.edu/media/Teaching+in+Zoom+Best+practices/1_hdw4elan; https://ru-stream.rutgers.edu/media/Communicating+with+students+Best+practices/1_ujifqspb and https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/1u9wL-G0Acsv8nhvHzYlkaArCqAN2ojAQkm1Bx9Bx1hY/edit?slide=id.g537a443357_0_3#slide=id.g537a443357_0_3.

3 Service

My service mostly builds on and derives from my main focus and strength, research. I provide such service in two main ways: 1) to the profession/scholarly field, and 2) to students.¹⁹

I review papers for journals, 4-5/mo or 48-60/year as of May 2026, including the top journals such as Journal of Personality and Social Psychology and Public Administration Review (see CV for details). Reviewing is the foundation of scholarly fields, and increasingly in short supply—something I can attest to as a journal editor. Since January 2024, I co-edit Social Indicators Research, the leading journal in my field of quality of life and wellbeing. My editorial philosophy is to be mentor and helper, not just gate-keeper—for instance, I am often in favor of revision prior to external review (instead of desk-reject), and I try to guide the authors, especially the junior ones.²⁰

My research-oriented service over past 6 years 2021-2026 to students is: published 10 peer-reviewed articles with students as co-authors, supervised 9 dissertations (4 graduated; 5 in-progress), served on 6 dissertation committees, supervised 6 data science master theses, served on 2 master thesis committees in other social science, and supervised 15 independent studies. I have also led brown bag seminars and organized a workshop on academic publishing.

And I am very excited about bringing to campus an award winning²¹ junior professor from Germany as a visiting scholar for 2 months in Fall 2026: Leonie C. Steckermeier. Leonie is a productive scholar already benefiting 2 of our doctoral students—we have monthly or so zoom meetings where we are already working on papers.

I contribute service to the campus and department. Over 2018-2022 I have lead the development of a new MS in data science and associated certificate program. This was a substantial undertaking and also somewhat challenging as the newly created programs are located outside of my home department. I have been serving since 2022 as a director for data science certificate.²² I have just supervised 2 courtesy appointments as volunteer researchers in DPPA—they have worked with me on research but also helped students in my class. I frequently serve as either ad hoc chair or member on Advancement and Promotions (A&P) committee. I find this service fulfilling. I contribute to promoting quality faculty in our social sciences and I learn about my colleagues. Other committee service is enumerated in the CV. As I have been taking on more leadership roles²³ I have realized I need also skills in project management, so I have just completed a project management course by Google on Coursera.

While research-oriented service is my strength and passion, and usual campus and departmental service is my duty, I am also mindful of Rutgers-Camden public/community service/engagement mission. I agree that as a public university, we also need to engage with and provide service to the public and community. I have assisted a number of Rutgers-Camden students in their community projects over past 5 years serving as a faculty advisor for, for instance: Olorunfunmi Adebajo's internship at the Camden County Community Development Office's Homelessness Assistance Unit,²⁴ Marlo Rossi's project at Walter Rand Institute and other projects on abortion,²⁵ and Ojobo Agbo Eje: "Camden Health Equity Data Visualization Initiative."²⁶

New Jersey first, but I have been civically engaged outside of the Garden State as well. For instance, I have used my data management

¹⁹In addition to these two main ways, directly and indirectly I also provide research oriented service to faculty and campus by helping other faculty with research, bringing researchers/scholars to campus (see CV), and committee and community service.

²⁰I am grateful to the editor of Journal of Applied Psychology who has guided me when I was a junior author.

²¹Publications: <https://scholar.google.com/citations?user=xjkPIhwAAAAJ&hl=de>. Awards: ISQOLS Prize for the Best Dissertation on Quality of Life, Well being, and Happiness, 2nd prize, 2023; Best PhD Dissertation of the Faculty of Human Sciences, Dissertation Award of the Otto von Guericke University Magdeburg for outstanding research achievements in the context of the dissertation, 2022; Second prize of the Fritz Thyssen Foundation for the best social science paper in German for the article "Eine Krise der sozialen Anerkennung? Ergebnisse einer Bevölkerungsbefragung zu Alltagserfahrungen der Wert- und Geringschätzung in Deutschland.", 2019

²²See certificates at the bottom of the page: <https://graduateschool.camden.rutgers.edu/graduate-programs>

²³Leading new MS in Data Science development, Polish National Science Foundation grant (PI) and associated team leadership, Rutgers Camden Chancellor's interdisciplinary research collaboration grant (PI), leading a research team of data scientists, hosting a visiting professor and leading an associated research team of PhD students, leading dissertations, master theses, independent studies, papers with students, community projects, and co-editing a journal, among others.

²⁴News item: <https://patimes.org/from-research-to-county-strategy-how-negative-learning-shaped-camden-countys-shared-housing-innovation>

²⁵News item: <https://theconversation.com/abortion-laws-show-that-public-policy-doesnt-always-line-up-with-public-opinion-274699>

²⁶News item: <https://camden.rutgers.edu/news/rutgers-camdens-urban-innovation-fund-fuels-transformative-community-projects>

skills to assist with data collection and management for Ohio Business Round Table, and Michigan Economic Competitiveness Study.

In the ideal world, I would like to continue with research-oriented service. In particular, I would like to increase my research group²⁷ and co-author more with students, and ideally postdocs. Chairing dissertations and leading independent studies would be also my strength and preference. I'm happy to take on more administrative duties such as editing another journal or being a graduate director for our PhD program.

4 Appendix

4.1 Research: my research in DPPA, and scientometrics (science metrics)

I see myself as research leader in DPPA (Dept of Public Policy and Administration; my home dept). Not only I am productive myself, but also I lead students in research and co-publish with them in good and reputable journals.

All my publications are listed on Google Scholar.²⁸ I have more than doubled my citations since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, from 163 to 353 in 2025.²⁹ According to Scopus³⁰: I have had about 4 indexed publications per year since 2017, and also my citations more than doubled between 2017 and 2025. According to <https://adscientificindex.com> I am within the top 10% of RU scientists (220/2,364 all RU, not just RU-C) on H-Index (Recent).³¹

But DPPA in my most recent merit pay has said that I “underperform” in research. I can prove I overperform. It is such a gross misrepresentation one would think it warrants a lawsuit. At a minimum it requires elaboration. I was asked not to compare to specific persons and not to be personal, so no names, just overall department stats.

Quantity of research output is measured at <http://researchwithrutgers.com>³²—both at research units/department level and employee level. The department (research unit: Graduate School, Camden: Public Policy and Administration) has 10 employees.³³ Over the years 2019-2022³⁴ the 10 employees of the department have produced 37 research outputs,³⁵ out of which 17 were mine,³⁶ i.e., I have produced about half of the 10 person unit's output.³⁷

2023-May 2026, the department has produced 33 outputs, out of which 13 are mine—I have been burdened with unfair amount of service over past 3 years (see CV), but still I have produced 40% of the department's output.³⁸

Visibility (and arguably quality and competitiveness) of the research output can be measured as Impact Factor (IF). As far as I can tell from <https://www.researchwithrutgers.com> or <http://scopus.com>: 80% of the department does not publish in high impact journals consistently. Since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, I have published 37 peer-reviewed articles, including 7 in *Cities*, a journal with impact factor (IF)=8.1.

I am the only person in DPPA publishing with students in good quality highly ranked journals. It is important that DPPA recognizes that research quantity and quality are 2 different things, and it matters that we not only publish with students, but also publish in

²⁷My past external funding includes the prestigious Polish National Science Foundation (PI), equivalent of the US Natl Science Foundation.

²⁸https://scholar.google.com/citations?hl=en&user=pz9RYloAAAAJ&view_op=list_works&sortby=pubdate

²⁹My citations on Google Scholar after having stalled for 5 years are set to increase from 350 in 2025 to over 400 in 2026: On April 28 2026, I'm cited at 143, it's 118th day of the year, so I have $143/118 = 1.2$ citations per day; $1.2 * 365 > 400$. There is even greater percentage increase on Scopus. <https://www.scopus.com/authid/detail.uri?authorId=23061538900>; and Google Scholar: scholar.google.com/citations?hl=en&user=pz9RYloAAAAJ.

³⁰<https://www.scopus.com/authid/detail.uri?authorId=23061538900>

³¹<https://adscientificindex.com/scientist/adam-okulicz-kozaryn/1552726/>

³²Appears to be down as of May 15 2026 (as of June 2 up again), but the underlying data are at <http://scopus.com>

³³<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/organisations/public-policy-and-administration/persons/>

³⁴I took these from my merit pay which I wrote Nov15 2023.

³⁵<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/organisations/public-policy-and-administration/publications>

³⁶<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/persons/adam-okulicz-kozaryn/publications/>

³⁷Of course, the measure is crude and simplistic as it doesn't differentiate research output's length and quality. Still, it is remarkable that over 4 years one person has produced as much as other 9 people. And on quality, too, as measured by Impact Factor of journals, there are only 2 people in the department publishing in high impact journals, I am one of them.

³⁸August 16 2026 update: I counted again on <https://www.researchwithrutgers.org/en/organisations/public-policy-and-administration/publications/> and it is slightly different: 15/38, but it doesn't change the ratio, I still published 40% of 10 person department's output.

reputable outlets.³⁹

DPPA seems to acknowledge that quantity of my output is passable, but DPPA seems to have issues with quality. Again, as per above, quality of the journals is outstanding as compared to the department. What I may be missing?

Maybe my main research topic, happiness, doesn't fit into public policy and administration; and my papers don't discuss policy implications? Again, as I said in the main Research section in the body of the document (before this Appendix): "nothing further from the truth"⁴⁰

Maybe the problem is that I don't collect my own data? But that's actually virtue, not vice. People who still collect their own data in 2010s and 2020s mostly⁴¹ just don't know the data already available for download—there is no point collecting data—the data needed has already been collected. I have very broad research interests and very varied research questions, but still was able to answer all of them with existing/secondary data, just had to use various datasets (for more info just google acronym + "dataset"): mostly WVS and US GSS, but also: BRFSS (>500k obs), Twitter data, CDC Places, SHARE, Goodreads, ISSP, EuroBarometer, Eurostat, ACS, PSID, ECV Colombia, CaliBrando, ARDA, WDI, FRED, PISA, and others.

Or maybe my research is not causal enough? Indeed causal inference is one way to contribute—agreed; but it is only one of many ways. It's neither necessary nor sufficient for great research.

I am contributing in different ways than causality (most social science research is not causal by the way): I have novel ideas and able to find the right data to test them—I use complex large scale datasets to study new relationships—this is my contribution as recognized by my field.⁴²

Urbanism is my usual independent variable—it can hardly be studied in a causal way, it is an organic process in the real world—almost all research in this area, my area of research, is not causal. Economists also have it wrong that complex stats and econometrics and instrumental variables etc give you causality—no they don't! They just get you little closer if done right, but the only way to claim causality is experiments (or sometimes quasi-experiments). Causality is not about stats or models, it is about research design. So if you want to do causality right in my area of effect of cities on happiness, you would have to assign people at random to cities and rural areas—it's impossible.⁴³

Still, some of my research argues that the causality may be present. (But again it is impossible to know for sure without (quasi-) experiment that is not feasible in my area.) Instead, I argue directional relationship, or possibility of causality if you will, by paying attention to control variables and avoiding overcontrol bias (Golden et al. 2026), using fixed effects (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Mazelis 2018) and even before-after comparison group design (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2026).

An endnote: It was already indicated on my CV (also sent to external reviewers):

note: this book is excluded from the promotion packet (this is a popular science book): Happiness and Place: Cities v Nature. Why Life is Better Outside of the City? Palgrave Macmillan.

³⁹Again, since 2021, we have published 10 peer-reviewed papers with my students in good journals including 3 in top ranked *Cities with Impact Factor of 8.1*.

⁴⁰See Diener (2009) and my own Okulicz-Kozaryn (2016). Likewise, there are clear policy implications of my work, for instance see Okulicz-Kozaryn (2015a), Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. (2014), Okulicz-Kozaryn and Golden (2017). My numerous *Cities* papers have dedicated takeaways for policy/practice section, e.g., see recent (Mikhaeil et al. 2024, Deb and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2022), and even if the section is missing, there are still policy implications, e.g., Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021).

⁴¹Most, not everybody. In rare cases, survey data collection still makes sense. And of course I am talking about survey research (my main area) only. I am not talking about experimental, clinical, and other fields.

⁴²By the way, some of the greatest research out there in the very top journals like *Nature* or *Science* is not causal—it's just a data visualization like a scatterplot, and yet it is the top of the top, cream of the crop research, that beats any other research causal or not. And this very top research in *Nature* or *Science*—what makes it the very top is the research idea and the right data, not causality—this is what I aspire to, and this is my research strength and direction—novel ground breaking research ideas and great data without causality.

⁴³I have recently reviewed a paper for a journal doing an experiment with urbanism. Urban-rural dichotomy was induced in participants experimentally with urban-rural imaginary. So yes, experiments are possible for urbanism, but in a lab only. This is a lab setting, experimental psychology, not my area of survey research in the real world with people actually living in urban v rural areas.

4.2 Teaching (teaching portfolio cont'd)

Research first: I spent most time on research, and I want to be a great researcher; but I also want to be a great teacher, not just average. I am dedicated to teaching. My main effort is two-folded.

First, I educate myself: I read on teaching and mentoring advice, tips and tricks on [nature.com](https://www.nature.com), [insidehighered.com](https://www.insidehighered.com) and others.⁴⁴

Second, I have a consistent system for improvement. For each class I use superb <https://orgmode.org> to keep track of the class notes and ideas for the future improvement. Each iteration I implement some of the more obvious and quick improvements, and keep other more difficult and or major ideas on file for later. Orgmode.org improves immensely note keeping and implementation.⁴⁵ While orgmode.org requires hi-tech Emacs, and is not suitable for lo-tech folks, any other system for note keeping and change implementation for class improvement seems like a great idea.

I ask students for their interests in first class, I make notes and customize each edition of the class to the specific cohort—the cohort-specific changes each year are very small, mostly related to examples I give in class and data. And often student interests are similar over the years—for instance South Jersey and Philadelphia and social problems such as poverty.

I work with students outside of the classroom; sometimes I have a quick “lab” before or after class time, when I come and/or leave early/late, but the main tool is a listserv, where we have class related conversations outside of the class. Listserv is especially useful in coding classes where questions come up as students work on problem sets—then in addition to usual in-class Q&A we have a listserv discussion. I have learned over the years that it works quite well—students tend to have similar questions, and some students also have answers—a listserv forum is an useful tool in addition to one-on-one (and more social). Listserv discussions are not only about problem sets but also about extra topics and tools not covered in class. I have tried discussions on Canvas but they don’t work—students don’t use the tool. Instead I use a proper listserv groups.google.com where discussions are delivered straight to a student’s email. I learned this approach when I took Gary King’s methods class at Institute for Quantitative Social Science: <https://www.iq.harvard.edu>.

In 2026 I took IDT RU-Camden “Communicating with students: Best practices” webinar and there was this useful distinction in figure 1: open classroom v closed classroom.⁴⁶ I realize that I used to favor closed classroom, but over past few years have been leaning towards open classroom. It seems to be producing better results (student learning, motivation, and engagement) in current post-covid AI anxious times.

We brainstorm various topics and approaches in class and ultimately students choose their own topic and bring their own data to class. Then collaboratively (class discussions and frequent presentations) we move the projects forward and they snowball into final class projects.

⁴⁴Here are some interesting reads I’d recommend: <https://www.insidehighered.com/opinion/career-advice/teaching/2025/10/03/what-i-learned-advising-120-phd-students-opinion>, <https://www.timeshighereducation.com/features/how-be-phd-supervisor>, <https://www.timeshighereducation.com/news/career-advice-how-supervise-phd-student-first-time>, <https://www.nature.com/articles/d41586-025-03229-8>, and Somers (2018), Tough (2014), Grant (2014), Dawkins (2004), BROOKS (2019), Hausmann (2019), Robinson (2006), Walker (2014), Robbins (2013), Zimmerman (2018), Jaschik (2019), MCKENNA (2018), Mansharamani (2020), Stephens (2026). And there are also RU OTEAR and IDT webinars, etc.

⁴⁵For instance, orgmode.org has fast and intuitive document structure with sections and subsections etc. Timestamps and keeping a log of changes are equally seamless. And it highlights nicely important parts along with my custom labels such as 'TODO', 'LATER', and 'KLUDGE'. I revise, update, upgrade, extend, etc the teaching materials frequently—for instance my visualization class has been updated over 200 times over past 3 years as seen from GIT commits: <https://github.com/theaok/vis/commits/main/>.

⁴⁶At minute 22: https://ru-stream.rutgers.edu/media/Communicating+with+studentsA+Best+practices/1_ujifqspb and slide 24 https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/1u9wL-G0Acsv8nhvHzYlkaArCqAN2oJAQkm1Bx9Bx1hY/edit?slide=id.g537a443357_0_3#slide=id.g537a443357_0_3.

Open Classroom	Closed Classroom
Personalized approach	Autopilot approach
Adaptive to ind. needs	Focus on expectations
Targeted outreach	Canned outreach
Connects content to real world	Teaches content
Relational and student-centered	Transactional
Classroom is a space for learning community	Classroom is a space for providing materials
Engages class	Monitors class



(Yorks & Anderson) 24

Figure 1: Open classroom v closed classroom.

There are many ways to succeed in my classes. Basic mastery of material is necessary for everyone, but excellence (A grade) can be achieved in multiple ways. Most obviously through mastery of parts of the material,⁴⁷ but also through writing a “publishable” paper using material from the class.⁴⁸ Students can also get extra credit to make up for some of the points lost elsewhere by doing extra presentations of material related to the class, using tools from the class for common good outside of the class, and so forth.

OTEAR RU “Developing a Teaching Portfolio” (Virtual Interactive Workshop) that I have just attended has inspired me to produce several more thoughts. Excellent teacher recognizes that students are different and helps everyone grow—one of my aspirations. To engage students I empower them to pick data and topic for class assignments. In my teaching I want to be “supportively rigorous,” where bar is high, but I am there to support.⁴⁹ Overall, I try to aim at the median student; for hi-achievers I have extra/bonus material; for lo-achievers I have extra support. I’m enthusiastic about the material (naturally, if I teach in my area, which often is the case), and it’s hopefully contagious and makes students enthusiastic as well—I want to lead by example.

4.2.1 Teaching in DPPA

My current classes and syllabi are easily accessible on my website: <https://theaok.github.io/teach.html>. I mostly teach cross-listed data science courses and there is departmental friction: DPPA (my department) wants me to focus on DPPA students, not data science⁵⁰ (neither prevention science).⁵¹ One reason is a claim that computer coding (Python) in data science may be inaccessible to some of the DPPA students. The good news now for even most coding-averse DPPA students is AI that can write the code for them, so it should be all fixed (as of 2025 seems to be working great), but let’s revisit in some time what’s best for students.

I can make the case that data science (and Python, not Qgis or Stata) is the future and benefits our students.⁵² We would be doing disservice to our students not teaching them the latest and the greatest tools, and instead sticking with dinosaurs such as SAS and SPSS. As always open to discussion here—but let’s be constructive: I would like to hear your arguments against Python—why we should not use it, and use outdated tools instead? An occasional cherry-picked negative comment by a student is not a reasonable argument, I was getting those with legacy tools as well, and vast majority of students are happy with Python.

Since 2017 when I have submitted my materials for my last promotion, there has been an occasional criticism of my teaching. In general it falls in one of the 2 categories: Python v traditional/legacy point-and-click software like Qgis/SPSS (again, the comments

⁴⁷There is common necessary basic core of the material, but then there are many paths that students can take with extra material individually, and it is enough to master only one of these paths. For instance, can go broad and use adequately most of the tools covered in the class; or can go deep and just focus on one area and go all in. For instance in GIS class, a student can use all the main tools covered for an A final project; or can use just one tool such as online visualization with all the bells and whistles for an A final project.

⁴⁸A paper that is close to be sent to a journal—some more work the following semester or in summer and we will be submitting.

⁴⁹One of the workshop participants came up with this idea and it immediately caught with me as a great way to go about teaching.

⁵⁰What compounds the friction is that there are more data science students than DPPA students. It is also difficult for me as in general I am trying to pay more attention to a median student, but I also need to be mindful of a fact that I am in DPPA department.

⁵¹I am on one dissertation committee and chairing one dissertation in prevention science—but DPPA is not happy about that.

⁵²Here is an accessible read: <https://www.theatlantic.com/science/archive/2018/04/the-scientific-paper-is-obsolete/556676>

were pre-2025 and it should have been resolved now with AI); and second category was clarity and organization of syllabus—"was" because I have attended to it long time ago.⁵³ To summarize, I did take student comments into account right away long time ago when I saw these comments when they were posted. I do take teaching seriously.

4.2.2 Letters from students

One highlight is that the skills learned in the classes work in the real world: "The classes I took with you are helping not only my scholarship, but my day job. Thank you [...] I greatly appreciate it." and "subject:Received a Job Offer [...] I would like to thank you for all of the guidance and knowledge during all of your data-related courses the past several semesters to help me get to the point I am at today." and "since graduating I have continued to pursue more projects in the coding world. Some analysis projects, business models, and even some fun web apps and game designs. I appreciate all the help and motivation you gave me in class as it helped me to really see what I can come up with from all of the useful tools, how to plan and build on projects, and skills gained from having you as my professor."

And they work in academia, and students appreciate my approach and style: "I am reaching out to explore the possibility of having you as my graduate advisor. My experience in your Data Management course left a lasting impression on me and I appreciated your approach and teaching style. I believe your guidance would be invaluable in helping me navigate the academic journey towards finishing my doctoral degree." and "This is Teacher Appreciation Week and I just wanted to take a moment to say thank you for all the hard work and dedication you put into teaching. Your passion for education has inspired and impacted me in so many ways. Your commitment to helping your students grow and learn is truly admirable. Thank you for all that you do!" and "Please know that I deeply appreciate everything you have done for me, and I recognize the many ways you have helped me grow as a scholar and, frankly, as an agentic person in general. I am truly grateful for you."

And my classes might have even contributed to retention in the program: "I have learnt so much about my region is really unbelievable and I have enjoyed working with you a lot. So much, I am actually considering STAYING in the program because of you!"

"It was not an easy period for me, but your belief in me made a significant difference in helping me see it through. I recall one of your emails when you wrote, "...you have a passion for this, pursue it." That statement has stayed with me. It reflected a genuine interest in my success, and I hope I am able to pay it forward."

Hi Adam!

My apologies for the delayed response. I have been basking in the successful defense of my dissertation and celebrating the end of this journey.

I want to thank you so much for your support throughout this process. I have enjoyed learning so much from you concerning all things quant and maps. You truly made the dissertation journey an enjoyable one.

You mentioned before that you were editor on a journal and some of my research would be a fit for the journal. When you get a chance, can we talk through what that would look like? I have yet to solo author an article and I believe that working with you would be a safe space to learn about the publishing process given your robust publishing portfolio.

Thank you again Adam, for everything. I'm glad to have you as a mentor and a resource I can utilize for the rest of my career.

Best,

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Apr 15, 2026, 10:19

⁵³I think in particular students couldn't count 1 week, 2 weeks, or 3 weeks time—I'd post assignment and say it's due in 1, 2, or 3 weeks from the date it was posted. I personally think it's super clear, but sure, student opinion is what matters when it comes to clarity of assignments, so now I put the exact date, say Apr1, and I also put it on Canvas calendar, not just on assignment. In addition, I elaborate on assignment instructions with detailed footnotes to provide yet more clarity—all of that has been fixed couple years ago.

subject: Re: Request to pay open access APC from prof okulicz-kozaryn [260318-025834]

[...]Reflecting on this journey now, I just want to say that it was a great pleasure to work with you and to meet you Dr.Adam. But in this digital world, we will continue to communicate for sure and maybe do more work together in the future.

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Apr 23, 2026, 10:07
subject: Re: grant opportunity
mailed-by:

Dear Dr. Adam,

I hope you are doing well.
I wanted to take a moment to sincerely appreciate you for your support throughout my master's program. It was not an easy period for me, but your belief in me made a significant difference in helping me see it through. I recall one of your emails when you wrote, "...you have a passion for this, pursue it." That statement has stayed with me. It reflected a genuine interest in my success, and I hope I am able to pay it forward.

I also wanted to share that I was selected as a finalist for the PhD in Global Urban Studies at Rutgers Newark, and I completed the interview process. However, after careful consideration, I have decided to remain at Rutgers Camden and move forward with my PhD here, largely to maintain stability for my daughter.

So you will definitely be seeing me again. :)

Thank you again for everything you've done to support me. I truly value your guidance

Warm regards

From:
Sent: Wednesday, April 8, 2026 12:19 AM
To: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <ao264@camden.rutgers.edu>
Subject: Fw: SEVIS Data Pull 4/6/2026 - Fall 2026

Dr. Adam,

I would be remiss if I didn't share that my day job includes working in Python all the time. The Director of the Office of International Students sends an Excel file each week that is essentially a data dump, and I've used all three of the classes I took with you to make sense of it each time. Without what I learned in your classes, it would just be a random Excel file - and I like Excel. This is just a small piece of it - I was emailing late into the night with her about ban lists and communication strategy, and that entire conversation would not have been possible without the visualizations.

I also create the attached HTML, which I share each week with my colleagues, and we've been relying on it for real decision-making. The HTML is about 85% for me - I regularly echo your point about adding notes to the data. That's what people talk about more than the visuals. They look at the charts, but they look forward to my notes.

I really appreciate everything I learned in your classes and your guidance in both my professional and academic work.

From:
Sent: Wednesday, January 21, 2026 11:21 AM
The classes I took with you are helping not only my scholarship, but my day job. Thank you. Again, thank you for sharing your knowledge and mentorship. I greatly appreciate it.

indep stu dec18 2025
Hi Professor,

I really appreciate it! Thank you so much!

Again, I am truly grateful to have been a student of yours and learn so much from you.

Have an amazing holiday!

J

2024-04-26 Fri gmail "Dissertation development credit issue and thank you"
Also - thank you. I realize that I have spent so much time this semester focusing on what I needed to do that I neglected to ever tell you how grateful I have been for our work together. I know that I can be a real pain in the ass, and you have definitely experienced that more than anyone else at Rutgers - six credits of courses with me and chairing my dissertation committee! Please know that I deeply appreciate everything you have done for me, and I recognize the many ways you have helped me grow as a scholar and, frankly, as an agentic person in general. I am truly grateful for you.

<2024-04-21 Sun> gmail: class "Completed sections"

"I have learnt so much about my region is really unbelievable and I have enjoyed working with you a lot. So much, I am actually considering STAYING in the program because of you!"

sp22 swb May 12 at 15:30pm

Hi, Dr. Adam. Here are the materials of my final work. I follow the instructions of JPAM style. The word document may not be as neat as the PDF one due to some technical issues. I am excited that it is my first quantitative paper, although there is still a long way from publication. Thank you so much for you help! Your classes have improved me a lot. I had never thought about being able to use these knowledges before taking your classes. Thank you!

Besides, could we keep working on this paper during this summer? It will be my great honor to make a publishment with you.

from:
to:Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date:Jun 25, 2018, 8:26 PM
subject:Received a Job Offer

Dr. Okulicz-Kozaryn,

I would like to thank you for all of the guidance and knowledge during all of your data-related courses the past several semesters to help me get to the point I am at today.

I was extended an offer with the Philadelphia School District as a Strategy Analyst with their Charter School Office. The office itself oversees Philadelphia's 84 charter schools (and 70k+ students). I will be doing a lot with the student level data in regard to performance/monitoring and helping with policy/research.

Thanks Again.

from:
to: "adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com" <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Oct 17, 2023
subject: Graduate Advisor Inquiry
mailed-by: em.rutgers.edu

Good Afternoon Professor Adam,

I hope this email finds you well! My name is xxx and I had the privilege of taking your Data Management course during the spring 2022 semester. I am currently enrolled in Rutgers-Camden's new PhD program in Prevention Science. I am reaching out to explore the possibility of having you as my graduate advisor. My experience in your Data Management course left a lasting impression on me and I appreciated your approach and teaching style. I believe your guidance would be invaluable in helping me navigate the academic journey towards finishing my doctoral degree. I am a part-time student with an expected completion date during the fall 2026 semester. My preliminary dissertation topic is research around the causal effects of a need-based aid program at Rutgers-New Brunswick using a quasi-experimental design such as regression discontinuity.

Please let me know if you prefer to discuss this over a Zoom call.

Best,

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: May 8, 2025
subject: Re: independent study

Hello Professor Okulicz-Kozaryn,

I have updated my github not only with my up to date notebook like I mentioned yesterday but I also uploaded this txt file as a writeup like you requested: <https://github.com/>

If there is anything else you need from me, please let me know regarding the Independent Study.

I also want to say I am very happy to have taken your classes and had you to work with for this Independent study. I want to say the knowledge that you have helped me obtain along with the projects created are very much so appreciated.

I plan not only to continue research for this topic relating to music and spotify, but I am also going to take these concepts and principles for designing and working on projects with some other future endeavors as well.

And if you ever want to contact me for the future for any projects or know of any good opportunities for work or any other connections within the data science community you can contact me at:

I hope you have a good rest of your year and you enjoy your summer!

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Jan 25, 2026
subject: Re: independent study

Hello Professor Okulicz-Kozaryn,

This was an interesting read, I agree, it seems to be a similar idea to that one project I did for your class. Thanks for sending this along to me!

I may take some inspiration from this and add on to that previous project for continuing music analysis trends in the real world.

Also, I want to share that since graduating I have continued to pursue more projects in the coding world. Some analysis projects, business models, and even some fun web apps and game designs. I appreciate all the help and motivation you gave me in class as it helped me to really see what I can come up with from all of the useful tools, how to plan and build on projects, and skills gained from having you as my professor.

Thanks and hope all is well with you!

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
cc:
date: Dec 25, 2025
subject: Christmas Greetings
mailed-by: icloud.com

Hi Prof. Adam,

Wishing you a very Merry Christmas and a joyful holiday season. I hope you're enjoying a restful break and some well-deserved time.

I've been thinking back on my time in the PhD program and remain very grateful for your guidance and support along the way. I hope the new year brings you good health, energy, and many exciting moments ahead.

Warm holiday wishes,

from:
to: adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com
date: Nov 28, 2024
subject: Inquiry about Data Management Course
mailed-by: scarletmail.rutgers.edu

Hello Professor,

I hope this email finds you well. Happy Thanksgiving!

I am writing this email after seeing the Data Management course you will be teaching in Spring 2025. If possible, I would like to know more about the course curriculum. The subject is an area of interest for me, and I am enthusiastic about enrolling in the course. I have thoroughly enjoyed being in your GIS class and I look forward to learning more under your guidance.

Thank you for your time and consideration.

Regards,

from:
to: Kelly Esterly <kelly.esterly@rutgers.edu>,
Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Aug 5, 2025
subject: Capstone Project
mailed-by: scarletmail.rutgers.edu

Hello Prof. Adam,

I hope this email finds you well. I am reaching out to you for your guidance on my Capstone project in Fall '25. It was a great learning experience to take your classes. I look forward to working under your mentorship.

I am also having @Kelly Esterly on loop so she could issue the special code for the course

Looking forward to hearing from you. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Warm Regards,

from:
to: adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com
date: Oct 19, 2023
subject: Research opportunity Enquiry

mailed-by: scarletmail.rutgers.edu

Hello Professor ,

I'm xxx and I'm currently in your GIS class .It is great learning from you and I have been really enjoying studying subject.

I was wondering if there is any research /project opportunity to work with you ?
Is it possible to come visit you to talk regarding this at your convenience?

Thank you in advance
Regards ,

to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: May 2, 2023
subject: Thank you
mailed-by: gmail.com

Hi Dr. Adam,
This is Teacher Appreciation Week and I just wanted to take a moment to say thank you for all the hard work and dedication you put into teaching. Your passion for education has inspired and impacted me in so many ways. Your commitment to helping your students grow and learn is truly admirable. Thank you for all that you do!

Respectfully,

4.2.3 Student evaluations—explaining few courses with lower evaluations

Looking at recent years 2022-2026: courses are at or above the department mean, with these exceptions:

- Fall 2025 56:824:721 Community Well-Being—this deserves a subsection on its own—see below.
- Fall 2024 56:834:535 Research Methods—a required statistics course—these tend to get lower evaluations in general. 3.29/3.43 (teaching effectiveness/course quality)—to be sure scores that are not great, but have improved slightly from earlier: Fall 2021 3.36/3.00 and Fall 2020 3.22/3.22 and have improved greatly versus before my promotion with tenure in 2018 (not shown in current form 1a): Fall 2017 2.70/2.60.
- Fall 2023 56:824:718/56:834:650/56:219:522 Data Management: 3.33/3.33 are actually not far from data science departmental mean at the time: 3.79/3.78—the Data Science Program has just launched and these courses were just newly developed for the program. By 2025 my evaluations went up to 4.60/4.40
- Spring 2023 56:824:728:40/56:834:653:40/56:219:521:40 Data Visualization: same thing as in the previous item.

Recent 2022-2026 course evaluations tend to be around department mean. Specifically, while my data science courses tend to be at or above the department mean, the 56:834:535 Research Methods is below.⁵⁴ Another pattern to note is that over the years the teaching evaluations have gone up versus earlier years. One reason is that I have developed earlier brand new courses for brand new program MS in Data Science and it was the first time I was teaching those.

Earlier years 2018-2021. Very low evaluations for 2018 56:834:535:A1 Research Methods—it was online class during the summer when my mother passed away. And the only other course with lower evaluations was Fall 2020 56:824:725, 56:834:608 GIS Public Sector at 3.29/3.30—to be honest I do not remember well that course and I am not sure what the explanation could be here—I might have experimented with new approaches.

⁵⁴In general, required (core) methods classes like this one often receive lower evaluations.

Fall 2025 56:824:721:40 Community Well-Being

The course evaluation had only 3 students, 2 students gave 5/5, one student gave 1/na. Angela Mann (097002630) was not fond of the class, but she does not seem to be enjoying other classes either as her transcript is mostly Cs and Bs. It may be useful to cite here all student text evaluations for this class for “In what ways, if any, has this course or the instructor Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn encouraged your intellectual growth and progress?”

“Hostility was created in the environment with comments and behaviors that was at first isolating and then uncomfortable to the point of discouraging attendance. I was often subjected to indirect comments made intentionally to create discomfort after voicing an opinion about subject matter. The professor also decreased reference to me and further created hostility involving two other students. To keep protect my well being I choose not to attend the class but still attempted to keep up with the assignments. Being Master’s Student completing a Doctoral level course my needs were not met academically and a key portion of my project, assumed by the professor at his discretion, was not delivered until a few weeks ago which impacted the overall production and completion of the final project. My grade was reduced from an A to a C in one day for one missed class and a late assignment. I was given a zero in participation even after having attended the class, and despite the conditions created to which I no longer felt comfortable to attend. I bring this review as a last resort as the professor is attempting to fail me and I need to defend my personal and academic position. All assignments have been completed but I was given 0s for presentations that I did not feel comfortable to come to class to complete based on the behavior.”

“This class was so helpful not only for understanding the alternatives and valid ways to measure quality of life and its implications worldwide, but also for developing skills in graduate level research methods! Dr. Okulicz-Kozaryn is excellently prepared to guide us in growing in both!”

“It’s the first time a professor has helped me build a full research project for publication from working with the dataset, to the analysis, writing, and interpretations etc.... His guidance encouraged me, gave me confidence in myself, and helped me finish the semester successfully, with a clear vision of how to publish research, something meaningful to my interests. He helped motivate me and gave me context about my growth opportunities as an international student, which strengthened my confidence and vision for the future.”

4.2.4 Paul Jargowsky class visitation, and my response

This evaluation should not have happened. There was clear at least potential/perceived conflict of interest.⁵⁵ I had a political action/petition with students to abolish Paul’s cherished PhD qualifying exam. I am rallying up students against Paul’s favorite exam and somehow the same semester Paul is set to evaluate my teaching. I went to the department chair Patrice and explained the situation and the conflict of interest—there were plenty of others who could have done the evaluation in the department, for instance Lori. I even found a great evaluator myself, Bill Fitzgerald from teaching matters—Bill agreed to do the evaluation. Still, it had to be Paul. Another reason, which I also explained to Patrice: the class was outside of Paul’s expertise, Paul doesn’t teach data visualization, neither teach or use Python in his research (not just for visualization, but in any respect)—you will see in the evaluation that Paul simply didn’t seem to understand much of the class⁵⁶ and the evaluation wasn’t helpful.

⁵⁵As a journal co-editor I am very sensitive to conflict of interest, including perceived or potential, and I cannot imagine a scenario where I would not honor it.

⁵⁶Even in this second and final attached evaluation below there are misunderstandings, and there were even more in the original evaluation, after which we have met and discussed and tried to understand each other.

Rutgers University-Camden
Department of Public Policy and Administration
Faculty Peer Evaluation of Classroom Teaching

Course:

- 56:219:521 DATA VISUALIZATION (dat sci)
- 56:824:728 DATA VISUALIZATION (soc sci/pub pol)
- 56:834:653 DATA VISUALIZATION (soc sci/pub pol)

Instructor: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn **Date Evaluated:** April 3, 2025

Note: Given the long time elapsed since the class observation, I supplemented my notes by watching the class video.

1. Subject of Class:

1) visualization techniques for data clustering, e.g. dendrograms and k-means scatterplots, 2) annotation of graphs using matplotlib, 3) “flipped classroom” to respond to student questions about a problem set.

2. Relevance of the subject to the course:

The content was appropriate to a course on data visualization, touching on important methods for representing clusters and relationships in data.

3. A. Was an assignment made: Yes _____ No ☒

Although no new assignment was introduced during the session, students appeared engaged with an assignment from the prior week and came prepared to discuss it.

B. Were students prepared: Yes ☒ No _____

4. Clarity of the ideas presented:

The description of the class as given to the students:

[apr3] clustering

a bit similar to previous scatterplots; clustering is about grouping / finding patterns, and very much data sciency!

we only scratch the surface here--just few popular vis for clustering;
i don't cover here the method, algorithms etc

Adam worked systematically through the material, alternating between code demonstrations in an online notebook and examples. The examples were presented clearly, but the presentation would have benefited from stronger substantive and conceptual framing. For example, the class could have explored more explicitly when to use a dendrogram versus a scatterplot with k-means clustering. For another, an “elbow plot” was presented as diagnostic for k-means clustering, but there was no explanation of what the plot represented, only that it tells you then ideal number of groups (based on what?). Without more grounding, the different types of visualizations are just black boxes.

While links to more in-depth discussion of the visualizations in relevant textbooks were provided, they lacked specific guidance (e.g., chapters or sections), which may make it difficult for students to locate the relevant material.

5. Manner of delivery:

Adam put students at ease and was very responsive to student questions. He made good use of examples, both simple examples using a small dataset followed by more complete examples using graphics from published papers.

6. Effective use of teaching aide(s), if they apply:

Rather than a whiteboard or PowerPoint slides, Adam used an online coding notebook, an environment for writing and executing code. This is an appropriate format given the material and the emphasis on coding. However, the notebook’s structure—one long, cumulative document covering several classes—made it difficult to follow at times, as his frequent scrolling up and down through the long document disrupted the flow. Segmenting the material into separate notebooks for each class or adding clearer section headings could improve clarity and pacing.

7. Student participation: The students were engaged throughout and asked appropriate questions. Adam had a good rapport with the students. When students sought deeper conceptual explanations (e.g., how clustering algorithms work), the responses could have gone beyond general descriptions to help students better understand the mechanics and assumptions of these techniques.

8: Other comments:

The syllabus and class notes would benefit from more careful organization and editing. Clearer structure, proofreading, and a consistent format would strengthen the professional presentation of the course materials and better reflect the high standards of our program.

More broadly, the course could be enhanced by integrating theoretical and design-oriented perspectives on data visualization—topics such as perception, cognition, and design principles. These form the intellectual foundation of the field and help students make informed decisions about how to represent data effectively and truthfully.

Adam’s course provides strong coding content and fosters an open, interactive learning

environment. The main opportunities for improvement lie in strengthening conceptual foundations, improving the organization and clarity of course materials, and ensuring that design and communication principles are integrated alongside technical skills. These adjustments would make the class more rigorous and balanced, aligning it more closely with the best practices in data visualization pedagogy. Without that, students may learn *how* to make various chart but not *why* certain choices communicate data more truthfully or effectively.

Paul A. Jorgensen

Visitor: _____

Date: 11/11/2025 Instructor: Bob Olin-Kay Date: _____
nov21 2025

Acceptance or comments:

The evaluation was helpful as it made me realize that my html bullet points didn't render and thus obscured readability; and it got me thinking about spending less time on code as AI takes over. Other than that the evaluation was unhelpful. I would like to raise several issues so that we can do better in the future.

Paul does not teach Python or data visualization. Neither does he use Python in his research. I was arguing to have someone else evaluate my teaching. I even found a replacement to do evaluation. Then I can't get the evaluation for 7 months (class was in April, I get evaluation in November) despite multiple emails and reminders. And then evaluation is mostly unhelpful as outlined below with my inline responses.

"the presentation would have benefited from stronger substantive and conceptual framing. "

It's a data visualization class, not math or algorithms class.

"an "elbow plot" was presented as diagnostic for k-means clustering, but there was no explanation of what the plot represented, only that it tells you then ideal number of groups (based on what?). Without more grounding, the different types of visualizations are just black boxes."

That's the whole point of the "elbow plot" to tell the number of groups. Again, it's a data visualization class, not math or algorithms class.

"While links to more in-depth discussion of the visualizations in relevant textbooks were provided, they lacked specific guidance (e.g., chapters or sections), which may make it difficult for students to locate the relevant material."

No. There is a reference to a specific chapter: "and especially machine learning ch: <https://jakevdp.github.io/PythonDataScienceHandbook/05.00-machine-learning.html>"

"the notebook's structure—one long, cumulative document covering several classes—made it difficult to follow at times, as his frequent scrolling up and down through the long document disrupted the flow. Segmenting the

material into separate notebooks for each class or adding clearer section headings could improve clarity and pacing."

There are not only section headings, but there are 3 levels of them: chapters, sections, and sub-sections (and I even police this in students' assignments—I take points off if students don't use sections).

"Clearer structure, proofreading, and a consistent format would strengthen the professional presentation of the course materials and better reflect the high standards of our program."

I was trying to discuss and get a sense of what Paul means here but I wasn't able to get detailed or specific information. As far as I can tell it's about writing style: Paul is traditional and formal. And I'm quite the opposite: modern, straightforward, and informal.

My materials have a clear structure and consistent format. I actually have a specific philosophy here to be straightforward and informal. I follow Zinnser's "On Writing Well: The Essential Guide to Mastering Nonfiction Writing and Effective Communication." For instance: "Never say anything in writing that you wouldn't comfortably say in conversation. If you're not a person who says "indeed" or "moreover," or who calls someone an individual ("he's a fine individual"), please don't write it." I was asking Paul for reference to his style, but I didn't get any.

I even wrote a paper on cluttered and ornamented grandiose prose in social science as compared to natural science: <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11192-012-0937-9>

So called social science "professional presentation" in writing can typically actually obscure meaning and communication. Again, following Zinnser, the goal should be simplicity and readability.

Per "high standards of our program"--i think my teaching has a good standard, e.g., my current students publish in good journals: https://theaok.github.io/okulicz_kozaryn_cv.pdf#page=6

And, what do we mean by "high standards of our program"? Is it formal traditional writing? Does such writing translate into desired outcomes, i.e. communication and learning? (especially in methods/coding classes). These are ever more relevant questions as we are increasingly over-burdened by information. Clarity, simplicity, and readability seem a way to go.

"More broadly, the course could be enhanced by integrating theoretical and design-oriented perspectives on data visualization—topics such as perception, cognition, and design principles. These form the intellectual foundation of the field and help students make informed decisions about how to represent data effectively and truthfully. Adam's course provides strong coding content and fosters an open, interactive learning environment. The main opportunities for improvement lie in strengthening conceptual foundations, improving the organization and clarity of course materials, and ensuring that design and communication principles are integrated alongside technical skills. These adjustments would make the class more rigorous and balanced, aligning it more closely with the best practices in data visualization pedagogy. Without that, students may learn how to make various chart but not why certain choices communicate data more truthfully or effectively."

These were covered in the course earlier. The class was geared towards the students, not towards the visitation, i.e. the visited Apr3 class was not self-contained, it did not include important elements included in other classes.

I did reach out to Paul to discuss, build bridges, and understand each other better. We had 2 discussions, somewhat helpful, but still I was not able to get enough details and specificity. I got a sense that it is time to wrap up, hence my lengthy response above. For the future, I am hoping we can agree to disagree and work out constructive compromises.

The evaluation was also helpful in a sense that I watched the class video and noted I could have had a little more eye contact and walk around more and be less on the monitor. But again as outlined above most of the evaluation is unhelpful--I hope in the future we can be more constructive. I am excited to discuss and collaborate on teaching. I think we could focus more on teaching.

Rev. 1/12

4.3 Service for DPPA

I see myself as research leader in the department—and I also perform research-related service: I'm not only productive in research myself but also lead students—over past 6 years published 10 papers with students including 3 in high impact Cities—I involve students in reviewing papers for Social Indicators Research that I co-edit, I mentored 2 students to publish in Social Indicators Research—I think we could capitalize even more⁵⁷ on my research strengths. We have graduate students, and especially PhDs—to be able to teach and mentor them to be researchers we faculty really need to do research ourselves in the first place.

DPPA is a difficult department and there is a great deal of departmental politics that I try to stay out of.⁵⁸ At the same time, I'd say I am collegial. Up until this point, for the 14 years that I have been in DPPA, I have never refused any service—I think that such full unconditional openness to departmental service is at least above average if not outstanding.⁵⁹

I go above and beyond on dissertation supervision. I supervise 5. The departmental recommendation is 3. In addition, I am supervising master theses in data science (I don't think anyone in DPPA supervises master theses), and I do many independent studies—in fact I think I'm doing more than anybody else in the department here. Over past 6 years 2020-2026, supervised 9 dissertations (4 graduated; 5 in-progress), served on 6 dissertation committees, supervised 6 data science master theses, served on 2 master thesis committees in other social sciences, and supervised 15 independent studies. Again, there may be some cross-departmental friction and DPPA may say that we don't need independent studies and master theses in data science neither dissertations in prevention science. Still, the dissertations are almost exclusively DPPA, and there is a good number of DPPA independent studies.

I have also been doing all sorts of service that DPPA wanted me to do:

- “data dashboards.” I did: <https://chedvi.onrender.com/>, and <https://maps-dppa.camden.rutgers.edu/index.php?search=map&title=Special%3ASearch&profile=default&fulltext=1> (available on campus or via RU VPN only)
- “assisting affiliated centers with data.” Done that too: professional services and data analysis for Community Leadership Center (CLC) 2018; Geographic Information System (GIS) workshop for The Walter Rand Institute for Public Affairs (WRI) <https://theaok.github.io/shortGIS/vShortGeoda.pdf> 2019; supervised public affairs PhD Zach Chengcheng Yue at WRI: Covid-19 in Atlantic County Spring-Fall 2025; supervised public affairs PhD Marlo Rossi at WRI: Abortion in South Jersey Fall 2025-Spring 2026. I can do more here and on regular basis, but of course need grants or consulting fees.
- “data mentoring”—I don't think I could do more here⁶⁰
- being collegial and collaborative. I have served on departmental committees (again, I did all the service I was asked for): Awards/Events 2012-25, Strategic Planning 2019-20, PR/Website 2012-16, PhD committee 2014-21, and Methods Qualifying Exam 2012-21. I offer folks help with data. I organize workshops (see CV for details): GIS workshops, brown bags, howto publish, and collaborated on a grant recently in the department. And just assisted a DPPA faculty member in GIS mapping project in Camden (2026). I am also collegial and collaborative in research—I've coauthored with over 20 authors (Scopus): <https://www.scopus.com/authid/detail.uri?authorId=23061538900#tab=co-authors>

⁵⁷For instance I could take students to ISQOLS conference, and I could be a program director for the PhD program.

⁵⁸I was thinking that staying out of the departmental politics is a virtue. But maybe it is a vice? Maybe that's why my department is saying that I could be more involved in the department? Again, I was doing all assigned service, but for some reason it appears the department wants more from me.

⁵⁹Paul was not happy with my service on his PhD/methods committee and removed me from the committee. I did my service, Paul didn't like it, so that's fine we have a difference of opinion—but still, I was doing the service I was asked to do. Paul may say I wasn't putting enough effort—I'd say I was productive and efficient. Planning for the future: Patrice says I should keep on chairing Events/Awards committee. The only 2 productive things I was doing on that committee was regular bi-monthly or so brown-bag seminars and an annual or so workshop (publishing, GIS, etc)—I volunteer to keep on doing those. Other things, I have nothing to do with: awards, end-of-year ceremony and faculty mixer are 100% handled by Patrice, Mike, and Lisa, and I have 0 input there (except, as always, I volunteer to review papers nominated for awards). Bailey lecture—I was hoping to have some input there, but my speaker proposals are routinely turned down. UAA pre-presentations—I have no idea about that conference; I offered to do ISQOLS pre-presentations, but Patrice wants to keep UAA, so whoever mentors students in that direction is best fit for that (if such person exists). Again, just being productive/efficient.

⁶⁰Again, Over past 6 years 2020-2026, supervised 9 dissertations (4 graduated; 5 in-progress), served on 6 dissertation committees, supervised 6 data science master theses, served on 2 master thesis committees in other social sciences, and supervised 15 independent studies.

I am happy to be a program director for public affairs and even a department chair. I wasn't one as I was never offered the privilege in DPPA, but again happy to do it! (I declined chairing MS in data science outside of DPPA as I thought it would upset DPPA as they are already upset I teach in data science program).

Again, I want to highlight that I did all the service I was asked to do for the department. And I want to point out that DPPA could use some more democracy and shared governance. Let's have more democracy, where non-full professors' voices are heard. Let's make sure people can grow, and pursue their own path.

We have these rigid structures both historical and current. Historical: someone decided probably 20-50 years ago we need certain class in core as requirement such as regional economic development, the person teaching that is long gone, the requirement still exists. Current: we have very rigid military-like structure with top-down decision making.⁶¹ Let's get rid of that and have democracy and capitalize on people's strengths and individual paths.⁶²

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⁶¹I've lost the plot—wasn't academia supposed to be free independent thinking and challenging the dogma? That's what I've signed up for. Do university departments best function as a authoritarian politburo-like structures or free flexible democratic structures?

⁶²For instance, let's capitalize on my data science strength in teaching—we already started doing that and let's continue. I'm better fit to teach data science than regional economic development or quantitative methods that should be modernized and redesigned towards data science. Again, I can make the case that data science (and Python, not Qgis or Stata) is the future and benefits our students. I am mindful of the fact that occasionally a DPPA student has struggled in the past, but now with AI that should not be a problem anymore. But again, as always happy to have a discussion here.

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